

GetTheFlockOuttaHere.org Testimony

Easton, MD Town Council

Norman Bauer - GetTheFlockOuttaHere.org - Director

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Good evening, Mayor Cook, Council President, and members of the Town Council.

My name is Norman Bauer. I live at 9109 Honeysuckle Drive in Easton, and I am the director of GetTheFlockOuttaHere.org.

I am here tonight to address the Flock Safety automated license plate readers operating at Lowe's in Easton. Each of you has received my extended remarks and a proposed ordinance.

Let us dispense with the easiest excuse first: these cameras are located on private property.

The Town regulates activities and equipment on private property every day through zoning, permitting, property maintenance, and public-safety requirements. Private property is not beyond the Town's jurisdiction. The question is whether this Council has the will to act.

These cameras do not merely observe a parking lot. They create searchable records of where ordinary people travel, when they travel, and which vehicles they use. Every driver is entered into the system without suspicion of a crime.

Speaking before the House of Representatives in 1984, Congressman and physician Dr. Ron Paul warned that millions of tax dollars were being spent on computer surveillance, calling it "a disgusting procedure for a professed free society."

Forty-two years later, the technology is more powerful, but the principle has not changed. In a free society, surveillance should follow individualized suspicion. Government should not build searchable records of everyone's movements simply because the technology makes it possible.

Promises of limited access, short retention, or responsible use are not enough. Policies change. Contracts change. Administrations change.

We are not asking you to regulate this system. We demand that you ban it.

Consent was never requested from the people of Easton, and it must not be assumed.

Remove these cameras and pass the proposed ordinance.

Thank you.